Coefficient criteria for finite nonnegative linearization

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Abstract. We give two sufficient criteria stated directly in the coefficients of a finite stochastic three-term recurrence. The first assumes that the sum of its diagonal and downward coefficients has positive geometric increments with ratio $q \geq 1$, and that the ratio of those coefficients is constant and nonnegative. A finite algebra construction gives nonnegative linearization, including products beyond the terminating degree. This includes the full positive Krawtchouk range and the dual q-Krawtchouk family with nonconstant increments. The underlying quadratic algebra occurs in Koelink's work on type B Hecke algebras. The second criterion gives explicit perturbation inequalities admitting a relatively open neighborhood of recurrence arrays around every Krawtchouk system in the interior of the positive linearization range. For symmetric finite systems, a quadratic decomposition reduces positivity to two nonsymmetric finite systems. This yields a parity-split criterion covering Szwarc's quadratic system for $p_0 \leq 1/2$ and a q-analogue, and explicit symmetric neighborhoods. None of the criteria requires computing general linearization coefficients.

Keywords. Finite orthogonal polynomials; nonnegative linearization; Krawtchouk polynomials; dual q-Krawtchouk polynomials; quadratic transformation; polynomial hypergroups.

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1. Introduction

Nonnegative linearization (property (P)) asks whether the product of two orthogonal polynomials is a nonnegative linear combination of polynomials in the same basis. For a finite system, the identity is understood on the orthogonality support. This distinction is essential when the formal product degree exceeds the terminal degree. In a normalization with $R_i(1) = 1$, nonnegative coefficients have sum one and define the product probabilities of a finite polynomial hypergroup.

The Krawtchouk case is classical. Eagleson [2] studied positive definite sequences for these polynomials in 1969; Szwarc [6, §5, Problem 2] records the nonnegative-linearization range as $0 < p_0 \leq 1/2$ for binomial weights $\binom{N}{j} p_0^{N-j}(1-p_0)^j$ when normalized at $j = 0$.[1]

[1] The linked author version, §5, Problem 2, printed p. 125, uses inconsistent parameter conventions: its

Our proof below fixes that convention directly from a two-point model. It does not treat Krawtchouk positivity itself as a new result.

Recurrence methods also have a long history. In the second note of his 1969 report, Askey [1, Part II, Theorem 1 and Corollary 1] gives finite recurrence conditions leading to a hyperbolic difference-equation maximum principle. The stated polynomial conclusion concerns products with degree sum at most N. Szwarc's later characterization [7, Theorem 1] treats finite as well as infinite systems through an auxiliary discrete hyperbolic problem. His 2005 survey nevertheless asks for criteria for finite systems, including Krawtchouk and its quadratic system Q_n (Section 7) [6, §5, Problem 2]. Here we seek structural assumptions on the recurrence coefficients that imply positivity for every finite product.

Koelink [3, Theorems 3.1(ii) and 7.8] constructed a triangular quadratic algebra associated with the type B Hecke algebra, and identified the corresponding q-Krawtchouk spherical functions. The dual recurrence in that construction is the geometric family used below. Our algebraic proof extracts its positive multiplication mechanism and expresses the resulting sufficient condition as two scalar patterns in a stochastic recurrence: a constant ratio and geometric increments. No priority is claimed for the algebra or for the resulting named family. For comparison, Miclo [4, Proposition 3.3] gives a spectral characterization of the hypergroup property at a boundary point for irreducible finite birth–death chains by entrywise nonnegativity of products of transition matrices shifted by eigenvalues of their leading principal submatrices.

The second criterion is quantitative stability. Around each Krawtchouk array in the interior of the positive linearization range ($0 < r < 1$, equivalently $0 < p_0 < 1/2$), we exhibit an explicit radius in the space of recurrence coefficients within which all finite products remain nonnegative. Its proof uses one positive term to obtain a reference margin, an error recurrence to control perturbations, and orthogonality to preserve exact zeros outside the triangle support. The resulting neighborhoods contain independently varying coefficient arrays, rather than only a reparametrized classical family. The radius is deliberately conservative and depends on N; no uniform stability radius at the symmetric endpoint is asserted.

Section 2 states the geometric criterion. Sections 3 and 4 give its algebraic proof. Section 5 proves the perturbation inequalities, including explicit nongeometric examples. Section 6 fixes the Krawtchouk normalization and compares the geometric recurrence with Koelink's construction. Section 7 treats Szwarc's quadratic system and inequality hypotheses away from the deepest products. Section 8 proves that criteria acting uniformly in N must carry equalities near the symmetric endpoint, shows that the stability radius of Theorem 5.3 has the optimal order in $1 - r$, and records exact counterexamples to inequality shape conditions at smaller r. The final section lists questions left by these results.

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displayed weights have mean $N(1-p)$, whereas its degree-zero recurrence gives $K_1(x) = (x - pN)/((1-p)N)$. Thus the displayed weights give $\int K_1 \, d\mu = (1-2p)/(1-p)$. Corollary 6.1 derives our weights and normalization directly.

2. Statement and conventions

For integers $j \geq 0$ put $[j]_q = 1 + q + \cdots + q^{j-1}$, with $[0]_q = 0$; in particular $[j]_1 = j$. Consider real coefficients indexed by $0 \leq i \leq N$, where $N \geq 1$, satisfying

$$\begin{gathered} a_0 = 1, \quad b_0 = c_0 = 0, \quad a_N = 0, \quad a_i + b_i + c_i = 1, \\ a_i > 0 \ (i < N), \qquad c_i > 0 \ (i > 0). \end{gathered} \tag{2.1}$$

Set $R_{-1} = 0$, $R_0 = 1$, and determine $R_1, \ldots, R_N$ by

$$xR_i = a_i R_{i+1} + b_i R_i + c_i R_{i-1} \qquad (0 \leq i < N). \tag{2.2}$$

At $i = 0$, (2.2) gives $R_1 = x$; induction at $x = 1$, using the row sums and $a_i > 0$ for $i < N$, gives $R_i(1) = 1$ for $0 \leq i \leq N$. The terminal relation is $(x - b_N)R_N - c_N R_{N-1} = 0$ on the orthogonality support. Linearization means equality of functions on this support, rather than an unrestricted polynomial identity when the degree sum exceeds N.

Theorem 2.1 *(Geometric increment criterion).* *Assume (2.1). Set $d_i = b_i + c_i$. Suppose*

1. *$b_i/c_i = \beta$ for every $1 \leq i \leq N$, where $\beta \geq 0$;*
2. *$\delta_i = d_i - d_{i-1} > 0$ for $1 \leq i \leq N$;*
3. *for some $q \geq 1$, $\delta_{i+1} = q\delta_i$ whenever $1 \leq i < N$.*

Then the recurrence has a positive orthogonality measure on exactly $N + 1$ distinct real points. Its normalized polynomials satisfy

$$R_m R_n = \sum_{k=0}^{N} g(m, n; k) R_k, \qquad g(m, n; k) \geq 0, \qquad \sum_{k=0}^{N} g(m, n; k) = 1 \tag{2.3}$$

on that support for all $0 \leq m, n \leq N$.

Lemma 2.2 *(Coefficient parametrization).* *The hypotheses of Theorem 2.1 are equivalent to*

$$a_i = \frac{q^i [N - i]_q}{[N]_q}, \qquad b_i = (1 - r)\frac{[i]_q}{[N]_q}, \qquad c_i = r\frac{[i]_q}{[N]_q} \tag{2.4}$$

for $q \geq 1$, $0 < r \leq 1$. When $N = 1$, one may choose $q = 1$.

Proof. The terminal sum gives $d_N = 1$, and $d_0 = 0$. Geometric increments give $d_i = \delta_1 [i]_q$, hence $\delta_1 = 1/[N]_q$. The constant ratio gives $c_i = d_i/(1 + \beta)$ and $b_i = \beta d_i/(1 + \beta)$. Put $r = (1 + \beta)^{-1}$. Finally $[N]_q - [i]_q = q^i [N - i]_q$. These calculations reverse to give the converse, including $q = 1$ and $N = 1$. ∎

The parameter conventions used below are

q	$q \geq 1$ (geometric increment ratio)
β	$b_i/c_i \geq 0$
r	$1/(1 + \beta) \in (0, 1]$
p	$1/r = 1 + \beta \geq 1$
p_0	$r/(1 + r) \in (0, 1/2]$
symmetric Krawtchouk case	$r = 1, \quad p_0 = 1/2$

3. A finite algebra with positive multiplication

Fix $p \geq 1$ and $q \geq 1$. Starting with $A_{N+1} = \mathbb{R}$, form recursively the commutative real algebras

$$A_j \;=\; A_{j+1}[z_j] \Big/ \left(z_j^2 - \left((q-1) \sum_{l=j+1}^{N} z_l + p - 1 \right) z_j - pq^{N-j} \right). \tag{3.1}$$

Write $A = A_1$. For $S \subseteq \{1, \dots, N\}$ let $z_S = \prod_{j \in S} z_j$, with $z_\varnothing = 1$.

Lemma 3.1 *(Basis and positivity).* *The elements z_S form a basis of A, and all their multiplication coefficients are nonnegative.*

Proof. Division by a monic quadratic over any commutative coefficient ring gives a unique remainder of degree at most one. Applying this successively in (3.1) gives the asserted basis and dimension 2^N. For positivity, replace a square by

$$z_j^2 \;=\; (q-1) \sum_{l>j} z_j z_l + (p-1) z_j + pq^{N-j}.$$

Every displayed coefficient is nonnegative. This rewriting terminates: give z_j weight 2^{N-j} and give a monomial the sum of the weights of its factors, counted with multiplicity. Each replacement strictly decreases this nonnegative integer weight, because $l > j$ implies $2^{N-l} < 2^{N-j}$. The final expression is in the unique squarefree basis, proving the claim. ∎

Lemma 3.2 *(Positive associative inner product).* *Let τ extract the coefficient of $z_\varnothing$. Then*

$$\tau(z_S z_T) \;=\; \mathbf{1}_{S=T}\, p^{|S|} q^{\sum_{j \in S} (N-j)}. \tag{3.2}$$

Consequently $\langle u, v \rangle = \tau(uv)$ is positive definite, and multiplication by every element of A is self-adjoint.

Proof. Induct downwards through the tower. If j belongs to exactly one of S, T, their product has the form $z_j v$ with $v \in A_{j+1}$ and has zero constant coefficient in z_j. If it belongs to both, the constant coefficient in z_j is $pq^{N-j} z_{S \setminus \{j\}} z_{T \setminus \{j\}}$ by (3.1). If it belongs to neither, pass to A_{j+1}. Iteration proves (3.2). All diagonal factors are positive. Associativity and commutativity give $\tau((hu)v) = \tau(u(hv))$. ∎

Put $E_k = \sum_{|S|=k} z_S$ for $0 \leq k \leq N$, and set $E_{-1} = E_{N+1} = 0$.

Lemma 3.3 *(Three-term multiplication).* *For $0 \leq k \leq N$,*

$$E_1 E_k \;=\; [k+1]_q E_{k+1} + (p-1)[k]_q E_k + pq^{k-1}[N-k+1]_q E_{k-1}. \tag{3.3}$$

The last term is interpreted as zero for $k = 0$.

Proof. For $k = 0$ the identity reads $E_1 = E_1$. For $N = 1, k = 1$ it is exactly $z_1^2 = (p-1)z_1 + p$. For the induction on N, write F_j for the elementary squarefree sums in $z_2, \dots, z_N$,

with $F_j = 0$ outside $0 \le j \le N-1$. Then $E_k = F_k + z_1 F_{k-1}$ and $E_1 = F_1 + z_1$. For $1 \le k \le N-1$, use (3.1) to obtain

$$E_1 E_k = F_1 F_k + z_1 F_k + q z_1 F_1 F_{k-1} + (p-1) z_1 F_{k-1} + p q^{N-1} F_{k-1}.$$

Apply the induction hypothesis to $F_1 F_k$ and $F_1 F_{k-1}$. The coefficients of F_{k+1} and $z_1 F_k$ are respectively $[k+1]_q$ and $1 + q[k]_q = [k+1]_q$. The coefficients of F_k and $z_1 F_{k-1}$ are both $(p-1)[k]_q$, since $1 + q[k-1]_q = [k]_q$. The coefficient of F_{k-1} is

$$p q^{k-1}[N-k]_q + p q^{N-1} = p q^{k-1}[N-k+1]_q,$$

which is also the coefficient of $z_1 F_{k-2}$. Regrouping gives (3.3). For the endpoint $k = N$, $E_N = z_1 F_{N-1}$, so the same square relation gives

$$E_1 E_N = q z_1 F_1 F_{N-1} + (p-1) z_1 F_{N-1} + p q^{N-1} F_{N-1}.$$

The tail endpoint identity is

$$F_1 F_{N-1} = (p-1)[N-1]_q F_{N-1} + p q^{N-2} F_{N-2}.$$

Substitution gives $(p-1)[N]_q E_N + p q^{N-1} E_{N-1}$, as required. This separately checks the terminating boundary. ∎

Proposition 3.4 *(Positive subalgebra).* *The space $B = \operatorname{span}\{E_0, \dots, E_N\}$ is the subalgebra generated by E_1. Every product $E_m E_n$ has nonnegative coefficients in this basis.*

Proof. All E_k are independent, since their squarefree supports are nonempty and disjoint. Equation (3.3) shows that B is invariant under multiplication by E_1. Since $[k+1]_q > 0$, its interior recurrence also expresses each E_{k+1} as a polynomial in E_1. Thus $B = \mathbb{R}[E_1]$, proving closure under multiplication, including products of total index greater than N. Expand such a product as $\sum_k h_k E_k$. Its coefficient at each squarefree monomial z_S is $h_{|S|}$. Lemma 3.1 makes that coefficient nonnegative. There is a subset of each cardinality $0, \dots, N$, so every h_k is nonnegative. ∎

4. Normalization and the finite orthogonal system

Lemma 4.1 *(Positive normalization).* *Evaluation $z_j \mapsto p q^{N-j}$ defines an algebra character ϵ of A. Put $t_k = \epsilon(E_k) > 0$. Then*

$$t_0 = 1, \quad t_1 = p[N]_q, \qquad \frac{t_{k+1}}{t_k} = p q^k \frac{[N-k]_q}{[k+1]_q} \quad (0 \le k < N). \tag{4.1}$$

Proof. For $h = N - j$, substitution in the right-hand side of (3.1) gives

$$(q-1)p^2 q^h [h]_q + (p-1) p q^h + p q^h = p^2 q^h \big((q-1)[h]_q + 1\big) = p^2 q^{2h}.$$

Thus all defining relations hold. The generating polynomial of the t_k is $T(u) = \prod_{j=0}^{N-1}(1 + p q^j u)$, whose coefficients are strictly positive. When $q > 1$, the identity $(1 + pu)T(qu) = (1 + p q^N u)T(u)$ gives $(q^k - 1)t_k = p(q^N - q^{k-1})t_{k-1}$ for $1 \le k \le N$, which is (4.1). When $q = 1$, $t_k = \binom{N}{k} p^k$ and the same ratio follows directly. ∎

Proof of Theorem 2.1. Use Lemma 2.2 and put $p = 1/r \geq 1$. Construct A, B as above and set $X = E_1/t_1$, $U_k = E_k/t_k$. Divide (3.3) by $t_1 t_k$ and use (4.1). The three coefficients are

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{[k+1]_q t_{k+1}}{p[N]_q t_k} &= \frac{q^k [N-k]_q}{[N]_q}, \\ \frac{(p-1)[k]_q}{p[N]_q} &= (1-r)\frac{[k]_q}{[N]_q}, \\ \frac{pq^{k-1}[N-k+1]_q t_{k-1}}{p[N]_q t_k} &= r\frac{[k]_q}{[N]_q}. \end{aligned}$$

At $k = 0$ omit the third expression; at $k = N$ omit the first. Consequently $U_k = R_k(X)$ for every $k \leq N$, with the stated terminal relation.

The orthogonality support follows from the real spectral theorem in finite dimensions. On B use the positive inner product from Lemma 3.2. Multiplication by X is self-adjoint. The vector $1 = E_0$ is cyclic because the E_k are polynomials of successive degrees in X and form a basis. In an orthogonal eigenspace decomposition of a self-adjoint operator, the cyclic span of one vector has dimension at most the number of distinct eigenvalues. Here the cyclic span has dimension $N+1$, so there are exactly $N+1$ distinct eigenvalues, and the projection of 1 on every eigenspace is nonzero. Give each eigenvalue the squared norm of that projection as its mass. All masses are positive, sum to $\langle 1, 1\rangle = 1$, and yield

$$\int f(x)h(x)\, d\mu(x) = \langle f(X), h(X)\rangle$$

for real polynomials f, h, identifying an algebra element with its action on 1. The E_k are orthogonal by (3.2), so the R_k are orthogonal for this measure.

Proposition 3.4 and positive t_k give nonnegative product coefficients for the U_k. Applying the character ϵ gives their sum equal to one because $\epsilon(U_k) = 1$. Polynomial identities in the algebra hold on every spectral point; conversely the R_k, having successive degrees at most N, form a basis of functions on the $N+1$ distinct points. This proves uniqueness and (2.3) for all products. ∎

5. A criterion for small coefficient perturbations

Write the tridiagonal recurrence matrix with the row convention

$$J_{i,i+1} = a_i, \qquad J_{i,i} = b_i, \qquad J_{i,i-1} = c_i,$$

with all other entries zero and indices outside $0, \ldots, N$ omitted.

Lemma 5.1 *(Finite recurrence realization and triangle support).* *Every recurrence satisfying (2.1) has a positive orthogonality measure on exactly $N+1$ real points. If J is its tridiagonal recurrence matrix, then its finite product coefficients satisfy*

$$g(m, n; k) = [R_m(J)]_{n,k}. \tag{5.1}$$

They vanish unless $|m-n| \leq k \leq \min(m+n, N)$, regardless of their signs inside this interval.

Proof. Choose positive π_i with $\pi_0 = 1$ and $\pi_{i+1} = \pi_i a_i / c_{i+1}$. For $D = \operatorname{diag}(\sqrt{\pi_i})$, $H = DJD^{-1}$ is real symmetric. Induction in (2.2) gives the row-vector identity $e_0^{\mathsf{T}} R_i(J) = e_i^{\mathsf{T}}$, hence $e_0^{\mathsf{T}} R_i(H) = \pi_i^{-1/2} e_i^{\mathsf{T}}$. In particular e_0 is cyclic for H. The same finite spectral argument as in Theorem 2.1 gives $N+1$ distinct eigenvalues and positive spectral masses at e_0, and

$$\int R_i R_j \, d\mu = e_0^{\mathsf{T}} R_i(H) R_j(H) e_0 = \mathbf{1}_{i=j} \pi_i^{-1}.$$

The terminal relation holds on this support: its polynomial $Q(x) = (x - b_N) R_N - c_N R_{N-1}$ satisfies $e_0^{\mathsf{T}} Q(J) = 0$. Since e_0 is cyclic and $Q(J)$ commutes with J, $Q(J) = 0$. Multiplying a basis polynomial by x acts by the corresponding row of J, including the terminal row. Induction on powers of x therefore gives (5.1). Orthogonality also gives

$$g(m, n; k) = \frac{\int R_m R_n R_k \, d\mu}{\int R_k^2 \, d\mu}.$$

If one of m, n, k exceeds the sum of the other two, its polynomial is orthogonal to their product, whose degree is smaller. This proves the asserted support. ∎

Lemma 5.2 *(A uniform positive margin in the asymmetric case).* *For the Krawtchouk recurrence (2.4) with $q = 1$ and $0 < r < 1$, put $s = \min(r, 1 - r)$. Every coefficient in its triangle support obeys*

$$g(m, n; k) \geq (s/4)^N \quad \text{if } |m - n| \leq k \leq \min(m + n, N). \tag{5.2}$$

Proof. Specialize the algebra above to $q = 1$, and put $y_i = z_i / p$, where $p = 1/r$. Then $y_i^2 = (1 - r) y_i + r$, and $U_m = \binom{N}{m}^{-1} \sum_{|S|=m} y_S$. The reduction of a product $y_S y_T$ has nonnegative coefficients, each chosen term being a product of at most N factors from $\{r, 1 - r\}$. Its coefficient is therefore at least s^N. For each admissible k, at least one such term has degree k. Assume $m \geq n$. If $k \leq m$, take $T \subseteq S$, with sizes n, m, and retain the linear term for exactly $k - (m - n)$ overlap coordinates. This number lies between 0 and n. If $k \geq m$, choose sets with overlap $m + n - k$ and union of size $k \leq N$, and retain the linear term at every overlap coordinate. Permutation symmetry makes the coefficient of y_U depend only on $|U| = k$. Hence the coefficient in the normalized elementary-symmetric basis is at least

$$\frac{s^N \binom{N}{k}}{\binom{N}{m}\binom{N}{n}} \geq \frac{s^N}{4^N}.$$

This uses a single positive term and a denominator bound, not an explicit formula for the product coefficients. ∎

Theorem 5.3 *(Explicit perturbation inequalities).* *Let $N \geq 1$, $0 < r < 1$, $s = \min(r, 1 - r)$, and*

$$\eta_N(r) = \frac{1}{2} \left(\frac{s}{32N} \right)^N. \tag{5.3}$$

Suppose coefficients $\widetilde{a}_i, \widetilde{b}_i, \widetilde{c}_i$ satisfy (2.1), with $\widetilde{b}_i \geq 0$ for every i, and

$$\max_{0 \leq i \leq N} \left\{ \left| \widetilde{a}_i - \frac{N - i}{N} \right|, \left| \widetilde{b}_i - \frac{(1 - r) i}{N} \right|, \left| \widetilde{c}_i - \frac{ri}{N} \right| \right\} \leq \eta_N(r). \tag{5.4}$$

Then the finite system has nonnegative linearization. Throughout its triangle support,

$$\widetilde{g}(m,n;k) \;\geq\; \tfrac{1}{2}(s/4)^N.$$

The product coefficients sum to one.

Proof. Use tildes for the perturbed system and untilded letters for its $q = 1$ reference at r. Let $\eta = \eta_N(r)$ and use the maximum absolute row-sum matrix norm. Both J and $\widetilde{J}$ are stochastic matrices, so $\|J\|_\infty = \|\widetilde{J}\|_\infty = 1$ and $\|\widetilde{J} - J\|_\infty \leq 3\eta$. Put $B_m = R_m(J)$, $\widetilde{B}_m = \widetilde{R}_m(\widetilde{J})$ and $e_m = \|\widetilde{B}_m - B_m\|_\infty$. Theorem 2.1 at $q = 1$ and (5.1) give $\|B_m\|_\infty = 1$ for all $m \leq N$. Also $e_0 = 0$ and $e_1 \leq 3\eta$.

Subtract the two matrix recurrences for $1 \leq m < N$. Writing $\Delta_m = \widetilde{B}_m - B_m$ gives exactly

$$\begin{aligned}\widetilde{a}_m\Delta_{m+1} \;=\; &(\widetilde{J} - \widetilde{b}_m I)\Delta_m - \widetilde{c}_m\Delta_{m-1}\\ &+ \big(\widetilde{J} - J - (\widetilde{b}_m - b_m)I\big)B_m\\ &- (\widetilde{c}_m - c_m)B_{m-1} - (\widetilde{a}_m - a_m)B_{m+1}.\end{aligned}$$

Since $\eta \leq 1/(2N)$, $\widetilde{a}_m \geq 1/(2N)$. The terms not containing a Δ have combined norm at most 6η. Also $0 \leq \widetilde{b}_m, \widetilde{c}_m \leq 1$, so

$$e_{m+1} \;\leq\; 4Ne_m + 2Ne_{m-1} + 12N\eta. \tag{5.5}$$

Set $L = 8N$. Induction gives $e_m \leq \eta L^m$ for $1 \leq m \leq N$: the base case follows from $3 \leq L$, and, for $m \geq 1$,

$$4N + \frac{2N}{L} + \frac{12N}{L^m} \;\leq\; 4N + \frac{1}{4} + \frac{3}{2} \;\leq\; 8N \;=\; L.$$

Thus every matrix entry differs from its reference by at most

$$\eta(8N)^N \;=\; \frac{1}{2}(s/4)^N.$$

Lemma 5.2 gives the positive lower bound on triangle entries, while Lemma 5.1 makes all entries outside the triangle exactly zero. Finally $\widetilde{R}_m(1) = 1$ follows by recurrence from the stochastic coefficient sums, so evaluating each product at 1 gives coefficient sum one. Here 1 belongs to the support because $\widetilde{J}\mathbf{1} = \mathbf{1}$ and Lemma 5.1 identifies that support with its spectrum. No product-positivity inequality for the perturbed system has been assumed. ∎

Corollary 5.4 *(Finite systems outside the geometric family).* *For every $N \geq 2$, take the Krawtchouk coefficients at $r = 1/2$, and replace only*

$$a_1 \longmapsto a_1 - h, \qquad b_1 \longmapsto b_1 + h, \qquad 0 < h \leq \frac{1}{4}(64N)^{-N}.$$

These recurrences have nonnegative linearization and do not satisfy the constant-ratio hypothesis of Theorem 2.1. More generally, Theorem 5.3 admits a relatively open neighborhood of the asymmetric Krawtchouk array in the affine space defined by the row-sum and boundary equalities in (2.1).

Proof. All initial and terminal conventions and stochastic sums are preserved. The bound on h is half the radius (5.3) at $r = 1/2$, and is smaller than $a_1 = (N-1)/N$, so all required signs hold. The perturbation theorem applies. At index 1, $b_1/c_1 = 1 + 2Nh > 1$, whereas at index N the ratio remains 1; these indices differ because $N \geq 2$. Thus this array lies outside the geometric family. At the asymmetric reference, all free coefficients constrained to be positive are strictly positive; the strict version of (5.4) therefore contains a relatively open neighborhood in that affine space; the sign conditions define the admissible region within it. ∎

6. Applications and scope

Corollary 6.1 *(Full positive Krawtchouk range).* *For every $N \geq 1$ and $0 < p_0 \leq 1/2$, Krawtchouk polynomials orthogonal for binomial weights $\binom{N}{j} p_0^{N-j}(1-p_0)^j$ have nonnegative linearization when normalized at $j = 0$.*

Proof. To fix the convention without relying on a named recurrence, put $r = p_0/(1-p_0) \in (0, 1]$, and let $Y_1, \ldots, Y_N$ be independent variables with values $1, -r$ of probabilities $p_0, 1 - p_0$. Their mean is zero and $Y_i^2 = (1-r)Y_i + r$. The normalized elementary symmetric sums

$$K_i(j) = \binom{N}{i}^{-1} \sum_{|S|=i} \prod_{l \in S} Y_l$$

depend only on the number j of negative coordinates. They are orthogonal, because the expectation of two distinct squarefree monomials is zero: some independent mean-zero variable occurs once. Their weights in j are exactly the stated binomial weights. With $x = N^{-1} \sum_l Y_l = 1 - j/(N(1-p_0))$, multiplication by x gives

$$xK_i = \frac{N-i}{N} K_{i+1} + (1-r)\frac{i}{N} K_i + r\frac{i}{N} K_{i-1}.$$

Indeed, in multiplying the elementary sum by $\sum_l Y_l$, indices outside a subset give $(i+1)$ copies of each subset of size $i+1$; the linear part of Y_l^2 gives $(1-r)i$ copies of each subset of size i; and the constant part gives $r(N-i+1)$ copies of each subset of size $i-1$. Division by the binomial normalizers gives the displayed recurrence, including $i = N$. Its leading coefficient in x is positive, its degree is i, and its value at $j = 0$ is one. These properties identify the normalized orthogonal polynomials for the binomial measure. Apply Theorem 2.1 with $q = 1$. The range is sharp in this endpoint normalization: if $1/2 < p_0 < 1$, then $r = p_0/(1-p_0) > 1$ and $g(1, 1; 1) = b_1 = (1-r)/N < 0$. For $N = 1$, this coefficient follows from the terminal relation. ∎

Corollary 6.2 *(The dual q-Krawtchouk case).* *For every $N \geq 2$, $q > 1$, and $0 < r \leq 1$, the recurrence (2.4) has nonnegative linearization. In the normalization $R_0 = 1$, $R_1 = x$, it is outside the Krawtchouk recurrence class.*

Proof. Its increments are $d_i - d_{i-1} = q^{i-1}/[N]_q$, so all hypotheses hold. For a Krawtchouk recurrence in this normalization the increments of $b_i + c_i$ are constant. Here their ratio is

$q > 1$ and $N \geq 2$, so they are not constant. An affine change of the support transporting the same endpoint-normalized basis leaves the multiplication coefficients in the basis unchanged; it cannot remove this distinction. ■

Proposition 6.3 *(Relation to the existing algebraic construction).* *The quadratic relations (3.1) are those of Koelink [3, Theorem 3.1(ii), equation (3.3)], with $z_j = u(x^j)$ and the same parameters p, q. The recurrence in this paper is the normalized recurrence of his Theorem 7.1, with $r = 1/p$; its polynomial-in-the-spectral-variable interpretation is the dual q-Krawtchouk interpretation described after his Theorem 7.8.*

Proof. The source square relation is $u(x^j)^2 = (q-1)u(x^j)\sum_{l>j} u(x^l) + (p-1)u(x^j) + pq^{N-j}$, which is (3.1). In Theorem 7.1 the coefficients of the next, current and previous indices are respectively $pq^i(1-q^{N-i})$, $(p-1)(1-q^i)$ and $1-q^i$. Division by $p(1-q^N)$ gives (2.4) for $q > 1$. For $0 \leq f \leq N$, the corresponding spectral coordinate is

$$x_f = \frac{p(1-q^{N-f}) - (1-q^f)}{p(1-q^N)} = \frac{q^{N-f} - rq^f + r - 1}{q^N - 1}, \qquad r = 1/p.$$

Writing $\phi_f(w_d)$ for Koelink's spherical-function values, we have $R_d(x_f) = \phi_f(w_d)$ for $0 \leq d \leq N$: the initial value is one and the normalized recurrences agree, so induction in d identifies them. As $q \to 1$, dividing numerator and denominator by $q-1$ and using the finite geometric sums gives $x_f \to 1 - (1+r)f/N$. The $q = 1$ case follows directly from the construction above, without division by zero. His discussion after Theorem 7.8 explicitly interchanges polynomial degree and spectral index to obtain the dual family. ■

The geometric criterion covers the full positive Krawtchouk range, including the symmetric endpoint. The perturbation criterion allows freely varying coefficients around each Krawtchouk array in the interior of the positive linearization range; its stated radius is conservative and decreases with N. Both hypotheses can be checked using a number of arithmetic comparisons proportional to N, without forming any general product coefficients or testing polynomial matrices. The proofs use positive algebra multiplication, a lower bound from a single positive term, and a norm estimate. They provide sufficient conditions, not a characterization of all finite systems with property (P). The geometric parameter family and underlying algebra predate Szwarc's survey; this paper makes no claim of historical priority for these constructions or criteria.

7. Szwarc's quadratic system

Problem 2 of [6, §5] does not stop at the Krawtchouk recurrence. With his parameter written as p_0, Szwarc introduces the symmetric recurrence of length $2N+1$

$$yQ_{2n} = (N-n)Q_{2n+1} + nQ_{2n-1}, \qquad yQ_{2n-1} = (1-p_0)Q_{2n} + p_0Q_{2n-2}, \tag{7.1}$$

records that $Q_{2n}(y)$ is the Krawtchouk polynomial $K_n(y^2)$ of his recurrence, states that the Q_n have nonnegative linearization for $p_0 \leq 1/2$, and asks for a general criterion that would handle this case. His Theorem 3.3 for infinite symmetric systems does not apply. In the

normalization (7.1) its monotonicity hypotheses hold, and its hypothesis $\alpha_n \le \gamma_n$ holds at odd indices exactly when $p_0 \le 1/2$; at an even index $2n$ it reads $n \le N-n$ and fails in the upper half. Some failure of this kind is forced in every finite system, whose terminal upward coefficient vanishes. This section proves the positivity of (7.1) by a graded version of the algebra of Section 3, and then gives an explicit coefficient criterion for symmetric finite systems near (7.1).

Put $M = 2N$, $R_{2n}(t) = Q_{2n}(\sqrt{N}t)$ and $R_{2n-1}(t) = \sqrt{N}\,Q_{2n-1}(\sqrt{N}t)$. Substitution in (7.1) shows that the R_k satisfy (2.2), with N replaced by M, for the array

$$b_k = 0, \qquad (a_{2n}, c_{2n}) = \Big(\frac{N-n}{N}, \frac{n}{N}\Big), \qquad (a_{2n-1}, c_{2n-1}) = (1-p_0,\, p_0). \tag{7.2}$$

It satisfies (2.1) with M in place of N whenever $0 < p_0 < 1$. The two normalizations differ by positive factors and a positive dilation, so they have the same product coefficients up to positive factors.

Theorem 7.1 *(Szwarc's quadratic system).* *Let $N \ge 1$ and $0 < p_0 \le 1/2$. The array (7.2) has a symmetric positive orthogonality measure on $2N+1$ points, and for all $0 \le m, n \le 2N$*

$$R_m R_n = \sum_{k=0}^{2N} g(m,n;k) R_k, \qquad g(m,n;k) \ge 0, \qquad \sum_k g(m,n;k) = 1$$

on that support. If $1/2 < p_0 < 1$, then $g(2,2;2) < 0$.

Throughout this section put $r = p_0/(1-p_0)$, so that $0 < r \le 1$ exactly when $p_0 \le 1/2$. Let A be the commutative algebra generated by $y_1, \dots, y_N$ subject to $y_j^2 = (1-r)y_j + r$. This is the algebra of Section 3 with $q = 1$ after the rescaling $y_j = z_j/p$ used in Lemma 5.2. Its squarefree monomials y_S form a basis, and for $r \le 1$ all multiplication coefficients are nonnegative. Call an element of A nonnegative if its coefficients in this basis are nonnegative.

Lemma 7.2 *(Edge idempotents).* *For $1 \le l \le N$ put $f_l = (r + y_l)/(1+r)$. Then $y_l f_l = f_l$ and $f_l^2 = f_l$. The ideal $f_l A$ has basis $f_l y_S$, $S \subseteq \{1, \dots, N\} \setminus \{l\}$, and $f_l u$ has nonnegative coefficients in this basis whenever $u \in A$ is nonnegative.*

Proof. First $(1+r)y_l f_l = r y_l + (1-r)y_l + r = (1+r)f_l$. Then $(1+r)f_l^2 = r f_l + y_l f_l = (1+r)f_l$. Let A' be generated by the y_j with $j \ne l$, so that $A = A' \oplus y_l A'$. Since $f_l y_l = f_l$, $f_l A = f_l A'$. The map $u \mapsto f_l u = (ru + y_l u)/(1+r)$ is injective on A' by the direct sum, which gives the basis. For the last claim, $f_l y_S = f_l y_{S \setminus \{l\}}$ for every S. ∎

Let $V = A \oplus \bigoplus_{l=1}^N f_l A$, on which A acts by multiplication in every summand, and call a vector nonnegative if all of its coordinates are nonnegative in the bases above. Define the A-linear operator

$$Y(u; v_1, \dots, v_N) = \Big(\frac{1}{N}\sum_{l=1}^N v_l\,;\, f_1 u, \dots, f_N u\Big).$$

Put $U_{2n} = \binom{N}{n}^{-1} \sum_{|S|=n} y_S \in A$ for $0 \le n \le N$. For $0 \le n \le N-1$, let U_{2n+1} be the vector in $\bigoplus_l f_l A$ whose lth coordinate is $\binom{N-1}{n}^{-1} \sum f_l y_S$, summed over $S \subseteq \{1, \dots, N\} \setminus$

$\{l\}$ with $|S| = n$.

Lemma 7.3 *(Three-term action).* *With $U_{-1} = U_{2N+1} = 0$ and the coefficients (7.2), $YU_k = a_kU_{k+1} + c_kU_{k-1}$ for $0 \le k \le 2N$.*

Proof. The lth coordinate of $Y\sum_{|S|=n} y_S$ is $\sum_{S\not\ni l} f_l y_S + \sum_{S'\not\ni l} f_l y_{S'}$, with $|S| = n$ and $|S'| = n-1$, because $f_l y_S = f_l y_{S\setminus\{l\}}$. Dividing by $\binom{N}{n}$ and using $\binom{N-1}{n}/\binom{N}{n} = (N-n)/N$ and $\binom{N-1}{n-1}/\binom{N}{n} = n/N$ gives the even case. For the odd case, $(1+r)f_l y_S = ry_S + y_{S\cup\{l\}}$ when $l \notin S$. Each n-set occurs for $N-n$ choices of l and each $(n+1)$-set for $n+1$ choices, so

$$YU_{2n+1} = \frac{r(N-n)\binom{N}{n}U_{2n} + (n+1)\binom{N}{n+1}U_{2n+2}}{N(1+r)\binom{N-1}{n}} = \frac{rU_{2n} + U_{2n+2}}{1+r}.$$

Finally $r/(1+r) = p_0$ and $1/(1+r) = 1-p_0$. ∎

Proof of Theorem 7.1. Lemma 5.1 gives a positive measure on the $2N+1$ zeros of the terminal polynomial $T(t) = tR_{2N}(t) - R_{2N-1}(t)$. Since $b \equiv 0$, the matrix J is conjugate to $-J$ by $\operatorname{diag}((-1)^i)$, which fixes e_0; hence the measure is symmetric and $R_k(-t) = (-1)^k R_k(t)$. Put $\Phi(f) = f(Y)U_0$, where $U_0 = (1;0,\dots,0)$. Lemma 7.3 gives $\Phi(R_k) = U_k$ for $k \le 2N$ and $\Phi(T) = YU_{2N} - U_{2N-1} = 0$. Every polynomial vanishing on the support is a multiple of T, so Φ maps it to zero. Hence the product identity on the support becomes

$$R_m(Y)R_n(Y)U_0 = \sum_k g(m,n;k)U_k.$$

The supports of the U_k in the bases of V are nonempty and disjoint: U_{2n} uses the y_S with $|S| = n$, and U_{2n+1} uses the $f_l y_S$ with $l \notin S$, $|S| = n$. Each basis vector lies in exactly one of them, with positive coefficient. Consequently $g(m,n;k) \ge 0$ for every k whenever the left side is nonnegative.

Suppose m is even. Since polynomials in Y commute and Y is A-linear,

$$R_m(Y)R_n(Y)U_0 = R_n(Y)(U_mU_0) = U_m\,R_n(Y)U_0 = U_mU_n.$$

Here $U_m \in A$ and U_n are nonnegative, so their product is nonnegative by the positivity of A and Lemma 7.2. The same holds when n is even, since $g(m,n;k) = g(n,m;k)$. If m,n are odd and k is odd, then $g(m,n;k) = 0$ by symmetry of the measure. If m,n are odd and k is even, then $g(m,n;k)\int R_k^2\,d\mu = \int R_mR_nR_k\,d\mu = g(k,m;n)\int R_n^2\,d\mu \ge 0$. The point $t = 1$ belongs to the support because $J\mathbf{1} = \mathbf{1}$, and $R_k(1) = 1$, so the coefficients sum to one.

For $1/2 < p_0 < 1$ we have $r > 1$. The identities above are purely algebraic and remain valid, but A is no longer positive. In particular $U_2^2 = N^{-2}\big((1-r)\sum_j y_j + Nr + 2\sum_{i<j} y_iy_j\big)$, whose U_2 coefficient $g(2,2;2) = (1-r)/N$ is negative. ∎

Since Y^2 acts on A by multiplication by $N^{-1}\sum_l f_l = (r+X)/(1+r)$, with $X = N^{-1}\sum_l y_l$, the even part of the theorem is Corollary 6.1: $R_{2n}(t) = K_n\big((1+r)t^2 - r\big)$ in the normalization of that corollary. Thus Theorem 7.1 recovers the full positive Krawtchouk

range by Szwarc's quadratic route. At $p_0 = 1/2$ the operator Y is the normalized adjacency operator of the subdivided N-cube seen from a vertex, and the theorem reduces to counting in that graph.

Lemma 7.4 *(Margin for the quadratic system).* *Let $0 < p_0 < 1/2$ and $s = \min(r, 1-r)$. For the array (7.2),*

$$g(m,n;k) \ge (rs/8)^N \qquad \text{whenever } |m-n| \le k \le m+n \text{ and } m+n+k \text{ is even.}$$

All other coefficients vanish.

Proof. The vanishing statements are Lemma 5.1 and the symmetry used above. We use $\binom{N}{k} \le 2^N$ throughout. Up to the order of m, n, there are three cases.

If m, n, k are even, the coefficient is a Krawtchouk coefficient computed in A, so Lemma 5.2 gives the lower bound $(s/4)^N \ge (rs/8)^N$.

Let $m = 2a$, $n = 2b+1$ and $k = 2c+1$, so that

$$\max(a-b-1,\, b-a) \le c \le \min(a+b,\, N-1).$$

Fix l and a set $U \not\ni l$ with $|U| = c$. The lth coordinate of $U_m U_n$ is

$$\binom{N}{a}^{-1}\binom{N-1}{b}^{-1} \sum_{|T|=a} \sum_{S \not\ni l,\ |S|=b} f_l\, y_{T\setminus\{l\}}\, y_S.$$

Every monomial coefficient of $y_{T\setminus\{l\}} y_S$ is a product of at most $N-1$ factors from $\{r, 1-r\}$, and is therefore at least s^{N-1}. Put $a' = |T \setminus \{l\}|$, which can equal $a-1$ when $a \ge 1$ and a when $a \le N-1$. In the $N-1$ coordinates other than l, sets of sizes a' and b with overlap o, retaining the linear term on $t \le o$ overlap coordinates, give monomials of size $a' + b - 2o + t$. As o ranges over its admissible values these sizes fill the interval $\big[|a'-b|, \min(a'+b, N-1)\big]$. The two admissible values of a' cover every c above. Hence $f_l y_U$ has coefficient at least $s^{N-1}\binom{N}{a}^{-1}\binom{N-1}{b}^{-1}$, and comparison with U_k gives

$$g(m,n;k) \ge \binom{N-1}{c} \frac{s^{N-1}}{\binom{N}{a}\binom{N-1}{b}} \ge \frac{2s^{N-1}}{4^N} \ge \left(\frac{s}{4}\right)^N.$$

Finally let $m = 2b+1$, $n = 2c+1$ and $k = 2a$. With π_i as in the proof of Lemma 5.1, (7.2) gives $\pi_{2a} = \binom{N}{a} r^{-a}$ and $\pi_{2c+1} = \binom{N-1}{c} r^{-c}/p_0$. Orthogonality gives

$$g(2b+1, 2c+1; 2a) = g(2a, 2b+1; 2c+1)\frac{\pi_{2a}}{\pi_{2c+1}} \ge \frac{2s^{N-1}}{4^N} \cdot \frac{p_0 r^N}{2^{N-1}} \ge \frac{2s^{N-1} r^{N+1}}{8^N},$$

using $r^{c-a} \ge r^N$ and $p_0 \ge r/2$. Since $s \le r$, the last quantity is at least $(rs/8)^N$. ∎

The proof of Theorem 5.3 uses only three properties of its reference: nonnegative linearization with sums one, a lower bound for the upward coefficients, and a margin on the known support. We record it in that generality.

Lemma 7.5 *(Stability of a reference with a margin).* *Let a, b, c satisfy (2.1) on the indices $0, \dots, M$, have nonnegative linearization, and satisfy $a_i \geq \alpha$ for $i < M$, where $0 < \alpha \leq 1$. Suppose $g(m, n; k) \geq \delta > 0$ on a set Σ of index triples. Let $\widetilde{a}, \widetilde{b}, \widetilde{c}$ satisfy (2.1), with $\widetilde{b}_i \geq 0$, and differ from a, b, c by at most η in every entry. If $\eta \leq \alpha/2$ and $\eta(8/\alpha)^M \leq \delta/2$, then $|\widetilde{g}(m, n; k) - g(m, n; k)| \leq \delta/2$ for all m, n, k; in particular $\widetilde{g} \geq \delta/2$ on Σ.*

Proof. Repeat the proof of Theorem 5.3 with N replaced by M. Now $\widetilde{a}_m \geq \alpha/2$, so the subtracted recurrences give $e_{m+1} \leq (4e_m + 2e_{m-1} + 12\eta)/\alpha$. With $L = 8/\alpha \geq 8$, induction gives $e_m \leq \eta L^m$: the base case is $e_1 \leq 3\eta$, and the step needs $4L^m + 2L^{m-1} + 12 \leq 8L^m$, which holds for $m \geq 1$. Every entry of $\widetilde{B}_m - B_m$ is therefore at most $\eta L^M \leq \delta/2$, and (5.1) identifies these entries with the product coefficients. ∎

Theorem 5.3 is the case $M = N$, $\alpha = 1/N$ and $\delta = (s/4)^N$ of this lemma.

Theorem 7.6 *(Symmetric criterion near Szwarc's system).* *Let $N \geq 1$, $0 < p_0 < 1/2$, $r = p_0/(1 - p_0)$, $s = \min(r, 1 - r)$, and*

$$\eta = \frac{1}{2}\Big(\frac{rs}{8}\Big)^N (16N)^{-2N}.$$

Let c_k be the downward coefficients in (7.2). Take real numbers $\widetilde{c}_1, \dots, \widetilde{c}_{2N-1}$ with $|\widetilde{c}_k - c_k| \leq \eta$, and put $\widetilde{c}_0 = 0$, $\widetilde{c}_{2N} = 1$, $\widetilde{b}_k = 0$ and $\widetilde{a}_k = 1 - \widetilde{c}_k$. The resulting symmetric finite system has nonnegative linearization with sums one. Moreover $\widetilde{g}(m, n; k) \geq \frac{1}{2}(rs/8)^N$ whenever $|m - n| \leq k \leq m + n$ and $m + n + k$ is even, and $\widetilde{g}(m, n; k) = 0$ otherwise.

Proof. The perturbed array satisfies (2.1) with $M = 2N$: $\widetilde{a}_k \geq 1/N - \eta > 0$ for even $k < 2N$, $\widetilde{a}_k \geq 1/2 - \eta > 0$ for odd k, and $\widetilde{c}_k \geq \min(p_0, 1/N) - \eta > 0$ for $k > 0$. Theorem 7.1 shows that the reference has nonnegative linearization, and $a_k \geq 1/(2N)$ for $k < 2N$. Lemma 7.4 gives the margin $\delta = (rs/8)^N$ on the stated set. Apply Lemma 7.5 with $\alpha = 1/(2N)$: then $\eta \leq \alpha/2$ and $\eta(16N)^{2N} = \delta/2$. Off the stated set, $\widetilde{g}$ vanishes by Lemma 5.1 and by the symmetry of the perturbed measure, which holds because $\widetilde{b} \equiv 0$. The sums equal one because $\widetilde{R}_m(1) = 1$ and 1 lies in the support. ∎

Corollary 7.7 *(Symmetric systems outside both families).* *For $N \geq 2$, $0 < p_0 < 1/2$ and $0 < h \leq \eta$, the array obtained from (7.2) by $c_1 \mapsto p_0 + h$, $a_1 \mapsto 1 - p_0 - h$ has nonnegative linearization. It is neither of the form (7.2) nor of the form (2.4). More generally, Theorem 7.6 admits a relatively open set of symmetric stochastic arrays, with $2N - 1$ free coefficients, around each array (7.2) with $0 < p_0 < 1/2$.*

Proof. Theorem 7.6 applies. The odd downward coefficients $c_1 = p_0 + h$ and $c_3 = p_0$ differ, so the array is not of the form (7.2); here $N \geq 2$ ensures $3 < 2N$. In (2.4), on $2N + 1$ indices, the downward coefficients $c_i = r[i]_q/[2N]_q$ are strictly increasing, whereas $c_3 < c_1$. ∎

A criterion for all symmetric finite systems. Szwarc uses the quadratic transformation [6, §3.5] to pass from a symmetric system to its even part. For finite systems the

converse direction also works: positivity of a symmetric system follows from positivity of two nonsymmetric finite systems, both read off from its coefficients. Any criterion for nonsymmetric finite systems therefore becomes a criterion for symmetric ones.

Theorem 7.8 *(Quadratic decomposition).* *Let $N \geq 2$, and let a_k, c_k $(0 \leq k \leq 2N)$ with $b \equiv 0$ satisfy (2.1) with $2N$ in place of N. Put $a_k = c_k = 0$ for $k \notin [0, 2N]$, and define the even component*

$$\hat{a}_n = a_{2n}a_{2n+1}, \quad \hat{b}_n = c_{2n}a_{2n-1} + a_{2n}c_{2n+1}, \quad \hat{c}_n = c_{2n}c_{2n-1} \qquad (0 \leq n \leq N)$$

and the odd component

$$\check{a}_n = a_{2n+1}a_{2n+2}, \quad \check{b}_n = a_{2n+1}c_{2n+2} + c_{2n+1}a_{2n}, \quad \check{c}_n = c_{2n+1}c_{2n} \qquad (0 \leq n < N).$$

After the affine normalization $(\hat{a}_n, \hat{b}_n, \hat{c}_n) \mapsto (\hat{a}_n, \hat{b}_n - \hat{b}_0, \hat{c}_n)/\hat{a}_0$, and likewise for the odd component, these arrays satisfy (2.1) on the indices $0, \dots, N$ and $0, \dots, N-1$. If both have nonnegative linearization, so does the symmetric array. More precisely, with $\hat{g}$ and $\check{g}$ the product coefficients of the components and terms with indices out of range omitted,

$$g(2a, 2b; 2c) = \hat{g}(a, b; c), \qquad g(2a, 2b+1; 2c+1) = a_{2a}\,\check{g}(a, b; c) + c_{2a}\,\check{g}(a-1, b; c),$$

the coefficients with $m+n+k$ odd vanish, and $g(2a+1, 2b+1; 2c)\int R_{2c}^2\,d\mu = g(2c, 2a+1; 2b+1)\int R_{2b+1}^2\,d\mu$. Conversely, nonnegative linearization of the symmetric array implies that of its even component.

Proof. By symmetry $R_{2n}(t) = P_n(t^2)$ and $R_{2n+1}(t) = tL_n(t^2)$ for polynomials P_n, L_n of degree n. Applying (2.2) twice gives, with $x = t^2$,

$$xP_n = \hat{a}_nP_{n+1} + \hat{b}_nP_n + \hat{c}_nP_{n-1}, \qquad xL_n = \check{a}_nL_{n+1} + \check{b}_nL_n + \check{c}_nL_{n-1}.$$

The row sums of the components equal $a_{2n} + c_{2n} = 1$ and $a_{2n+1} + c_{2n+1} = 1$; the coefficients $\hat{a}_n, \check{a}_n$ are positive below the last index and vanish there, and $\hat{c}_n, \check{c}_n > 0$ for $n \geq 1$. Hence the normalized arrays, which describe the same polynomials in the variable $(x - \hat{b}_0)/\hat{a}_0$ (respectively $(x - \check{b}_0)/\check{a}_0$), satisfy (2.1). The terminal relation $tR_{2N} = c_{2N}R_{2N-1}$ on the support Σ of the symmetric system, applied once and twice, gives the terminal relations of P on $\{t^2 : t \in \Sigma\}$ and of L on $\{t^2 : t \in \Sigma,\ t \neq 0\}$. These sets have $N+1$ and N points, because Σ is symmetric with $2N+1$ points and contains 0. By Lemma 5.1 they are the supports of the two components.

The identity $tR_{2n} = a_{2n}R_{2n+1} + c_{2n}R_{2n-1}$ gives $P_n = a_{2n}L_n + c_{2n}L_{n-1}$ on the support of L; for $n = N$ it is the terminal relation, with $a_{2N} = 0$. Hence, on $\Sigma \setminus \{0\}$,

$$R_{2a}R_{2b+1} = t\big(a_{2a}L_aL_b + c_{2a}L_{a-1}L_b\big) = \sum_c \big(a_{2a}\check{g}(a, b; c) + c_{2a}\check{g}(a-1, b; c)\big)R_{2c+1},$$

and both sides vanish at $t = 0$. Similarly $R_{2a}R_{2b} = (P_aP_b)(t^2) = \sum_c \hat{g}(a, b; c)R_{2c}$ on Σ. Uniqueness of expansions on Σ gives the displayed formulas. The vanishing for $m+n+k$ odd and the relation for two odd indices follow from the symmetry of the measure and from $g(m, n; k)\int R_k^2\,d\mu = \int R_mR_nR_k\,d\mu$, exactly as in the proof of Theorem 7.1. The converse holds because $\hat{g}(a, b; c) = g(2a, 2b; 2c)$. ∎

Combined with Theorem 2.1, the decomposition gives a parity-split criterion of the same shape as Szwarc's Theorem 3.3: separate conditions on the even-indexed and the odd-indexed coefficients.

Corollary 7.9 *(Parity-split criterion).* *Let $N \geq 1$ and let a symmetric array ($b \equiv 0$) on the indices $0, \dots, 2N$ satisfy (2.1). Suppose that*

1. *the odd downward coefficients are constant, $c_{2n+1} = p_0$, with $0 < p_0 \leq 1/2$;*
2. *the even downward coefficients $d_n = c_{2n}$ have positive increments $d_n - d_{n-1}$, $1 \leq n \leq N$, forming a geometric progression with ratio $q \geq 1$.*

Then the array has nonnegative linearization. With $r = p_0/(1-p_0)$, its even component is (2.4) with parameters (N, q, r) and its odd component is (2.4) with parameters $(N-1, q, r/q)$. If $1/2 < p_0 < 1$ in (i) and (ii) holds, then $g(2,2;2) < 0$.

Proof. For $N = 1$ this is Theorem 7.1. Let $N \geq 2$. The even component has $\hat{a}_n = (1-d_n)(1-p_0)$, $\hat{b}_n = d_n(1-p_0) + (1-d_n)p_0$ and $\hat{c}_n = d_n p_0$, so $\hat{a}_0 = 1-p_0$, $\hat{b}_0 = p_0$, and its normalization is $(1-d_n, (1-r)d_n, rd_n)$. This satisfies Theorem 2.1 with $\beta = (1-r)/r \geq 0$. For the odd component, $\check{a}_n = (1-p_0)(1-d_{n+1})$, $\check{b}_n = (1-p_0)d_{n+1} + p_0(1-d_n)$ and $\check{c}_n = p_0 d_n$. Geometric increments give $d_{n+1} - d_1 = q d_n$, so the normalization is

$$\Big(\frac{1-d_{n+1}}{1-d_1},\ \frac{(q-r)d_n}{1-d_1},\ \frac{rd_n}{1-d_1}\Big).$$

Its ratio $\beta = (q-r)/r$ is constant and nonnegative, and its profile $qd_n/(1-d_1)$ has geometric increments with ratio q. Theorem 2.1 applies to both components, and Theorem 7.8 concludes. Lemma 2.2 identifies the parameters. For $p_0 > 1/2$, $g(2,2;2) = \hat{g}(1,1;1)$ is the normalized diagonal coefficient $(1-r)d_1 < 0$ (for $N = 1$ see Theorem 7.1). ∎

With $q = 1$ the corollary is Szwarc's system (7.2), and it recovers Theorem 7.1, including the Krawtchouk polynomials as its even component. For $q > 1$ it gives a three-parameter family of symmetric finite systems with nonnegative linearization whose even components are the dual q-Krawtchouk arrays of Corollary 6.2. Theorem 7.8 also transfers the perturbation criteria: a symmetric array has nonnegative linearization whenever its two normalized components satisfy the hypotheses of Theorem 5.3, or those of Lemma 7.5 around any reference with a margin. Conversely, the even component of every array admitted by Theorem 7.6 is a nonsymmetric finite system with nonnegative linearization.

Products of low total degree. Szwarc's inequality method [6, Theorems 3.2 and 3.4] survives the passage to finite systems for all products whose two factors have total degree at most N. Only the terminal coefficients are excluded from its hypotheses. Write a finite system in a positive renormalization $P_n = R_n/\sigma_n$ ($\sigma_0 = 1$) as $xP_n = \gamma_n P_{n+1} + \beta_n P_n + \alpha_n P_{n-1}$, so that $\gamma_n = a_n\sigma_{n+1}/\sigma_n$, $\beta_n = b_n$, $\alpha_n = c_n\sigma_{n-1}/\sigma_n$ and $\gamma_N = 0$.

Theorem 7.10 *(Low products).* *Let a, b, c satisfy (2.1). Suppose that for some positive σ,*

1. *β_n is nondecreasing for $0 \leq n \leq N-1$, and α_n is nondecreasing for $0 \leq n \leq N$;*

2. $\alpha_n + \gamma_n$ *is nondecreasing for* $0 \le n \le N-2$;

3. $\gamma_i \ge \alpha_j$ *whenever* $0 \le j \le i$ *and* $i + j \le N-2$.

Then $g(n,m;k) \ge 0$ *whenever* $n+m \le N$. *Consequently a product coefficient can be negative only for a triple* (n,m,k) *in which each two indices have sum greater than* N.

Proof. Coefficients in two positive normalizations differ by positive factors, so we may work with the polynomials $\widetilde{P}_n$ of [6, (3.9)], which satisfy $x\widetilde{P}_n = \alpha_{n+1}\widetilde{P}_{n+1} + \beta_n\widetilde{P}_n + \gamma_{n-1}\widetilde{P}_{n-1}$ with $\alpha_{N+1} = 0$. Fix k and let $u(n,m)$ be the coefficient of $\widetilde{P}_k$ in $\widetilde{P}_n\widetilde{P}_m$. Multiplying the product by x in the two ways shows $Hu = 0$ at every point of $\{0,\dots,N\}^2$, where $H = L_1 - L_2$ is the operator of [6, §3.4] built from these coefficients, and $u(n,0) = \mathbf{1}_{n=k}$, $u(n,m) = u(m,n)$.

We prove $u(n,m) \ge 0$ for $n \ge m$, $n+m \le N$, by induction on m, following [6, Theorem 3.4]. Let v be the indicator of the points (i,j) with $j < m$, $|i-n| < m-j$ and $n+m-i-j$ odd. Every point in the support of v satisfies $j < i$ and $i+j \le n+m-1 \le N-1$, so $\langle Hu, v\rangle = 0$ involves only rows where the finite recurrence holds. Hence $0 = \langle u, H^*v\rangle$, and every point in the support of H^*v has $i+j \le n+m \le N$. The computation of [6, §3.4] gives the values of H^*v. At (n,m) it is $-\alpha_m < 0$. At the other points it is one of

$$\beta_i - \beta_j, \quad (\alpha_i+\gamma_i) - (\alpha_j+\gamma_j), \quad \alpha_i - \alpha_j, \quad \gamma_i - \alpha_j,$$

with $j \le i$. The first occurs only for $i \le N-1$. The second occurs only at interior points, where $i+j \le n+m-2 \le N-2$. The third occurs on the edge $i+j = n+m$. The last occurs on the edge $i-j = n-m$, where $i+j \le N-2$. Hypotheses (i)–(iii) make all of these nonnegative, and all such points have second coordinate less than m. By the induction hypothesis and $u(i,0) \ge 0$, $\alpha_m u(n,m) = \sum_{(i,j)\neq(n,m)} (H^*v)(i,j)u(i,j) \ge 0$. For the last statement, $g(n,m;k)$, $g(n,k;m)$ and $g(m,k;n)$ are positive multiples of $\int R_nR_mR_k\,d\mu$. ∎

Corollary 7.11 *(Convex profiles).* *Let* $b_i = (1-r)d_i$, $c_i = rd_i$, $a_i = 1-d_i$ *with* $0 < r \le 1$ *and a convex profile* $0 = d_0 < d_1 < \cdots < d_N = 1$, *that is, with nondecreasing increments. Then* $g(n,m;k) \ge 0$ *whenever two of* n,m,k *have sum at most* N. *This includes every array* (2.4).

Proof. Take $\sigma_n = r^{n/2}$. Then $\alpha_n = \sqrt{r}\,d_n$ and $\gamma_n = \sqrt{r}\,(1-d_n)$, so α and $\beta = (1-r)d$ are nondecreasing and $\alpha_n + \gamma_n = \sqrt{r}$ is constant. Convexity and $d_0 = 0$ give $d_i + d_j \le d_{i+j}$, so $\gamma_i - \alpha_j = \sqrt{r}\,(1-d_i-d_j) \ge \sqrt{r}\,(1-d_{i+j}) > 0$ for $i+j \le N-2$. Theorem 7.10 applies. ∎

For such profiles, positivity can therefore fail only on triples with all pairwise sums above N. The convex counterexamples recorded in Section 9 fail at (N,N,N), which is such a triple.

Deep triples and reversal. Call (n,m,k) deep if each two of its indices have sum greater than N. The reversed array $a'_i = c_{N-i}$, $b'_i = b_{N-i}$, $c'_i = a_{N-i}$ defines polynomials R'_i with

$R'_0 = 1$ and the same recurrence form; its matrix is $\Pi J \Pi$, where Π reverses the order of the indices. Write g' for its product coefficients.

Lemma 7.12 *(Reversal identity).* *On the support, $R_N R'_t = R_{N-t}$ for $0 \le t \le N$.*

Proof. From $e_0^{\mathsf{T}} R_i(J) = e_i^{\mathsf{T}}$ for the array and for its reversal, $e_N^{\mathsf{T}} R'_t(J) = e_{N-t}^{\mathsf{T}}$. Hence $e_0^{\mathsf{T}} R_N(J) R'_t(J) = e_N^{\mathsf{T}} R'_t(J) = e_0^{\mathsf{T}} R_{N-t}(J)$. Both matrices commute with J and e_0 is cyclic, so $R_N(J) R'_t(J) = R_{N-t}(J)$, which is the claim on the spectrum. ∎

Theorem 7.13 *(Deep reduction).* *For every array satisfying (2.1) and every deep triple (x, y, z),*

$$g(x, y; z) = \sum_{t=0}^{N} g'(N - x, N - y; t)\, g(N, N - t; z).$$

Moreover $g(N, N; N - l)$ is the coefficient of R'_l in R_N. Hence all coefficients are nonnegative if (a) $g \ge 0$ on non-deep triples, (b) $g'(i, j; t) \ge 0$ whenever $i + j < N$, and (c) R_N is a nonnegative combination of $R'_0, \dots, R'_N$.

Proof. By Lemma 7.12, $R_x = R_N R'_{N-x}$ and $R_y = R_N R'_{N-y}$ on the support. Expanding $R'_{N-x} R'_{N-y} = \sum_t g'(N - x, N - y; t) R'_t$ and using Lemma 7.12 again gives $R_x R_y = \sum_t g'(N - x, N - y; t) R_N R_{N-t}$. Expanding $R_N R_{N-t}$ gives the formula. Writing $R_N = \sum_l e_l R'_l$, Lemma 7.12 gives $R_N^2 = \sum_l e_l R_{N-l}$, so $e_l = g(N, N; N - l)$. For the last statement, $(N - x) + (N - y) < N$, so (b) makes the weights g' nonnegative. It remains to see $g(N, n; z) \ge 0$. If (N, n, z) is not deep this is (a). Otherwise $n + z > N$, and $g(N, n; z)$ is a positive multiple of $g(n, z; N) = \sum_t g'(N - n, N - z; t)\, g(N, N - t; N)$; here $g(N, N - t; N)$ is a positive multiple of $g(N, N; N - t)$, which is nonnegative by (c). ∎

Theorem 7.14 *(Palindromic criterion).* *Let a, b, c satisfy (2.1) with $a_n = c_{N-n}$ and $b_n = b_{N-n}$ for all n, and satisfy the hypotheses of Theorem 7.10 for some positive σ. Then the system has nonnegative linearization.*

Proof. The reversed array equals the array, so $R' = R$ and $g' = g$. Theorem 7.10 gives $g \ge 0$ on all non-deep triples, in particular $g'(i, j; t) \ge 0$ for $i + j < N$. Since $R_N = R'_N$ is a single reversed polynomial, $g(N, N; \cdot) \ge 0$. Theorem 7.13 gives the deep triples. ∎

Corollary 7.15 *(Monotone palindromic systems).* *Let $b \equiv 0$, $a_n = 1 - c_n$, and let $0 = c_0 < c_1 \le c_2 \le \cdots \le c_N = 1$ satisfy $c_n + c_{N-n} = 1$. Then the system has nonnegative linearization. This includes the symmetric Krawtchouk array $c_n = n/N$.*

Proof. The array is palindromic. With $\sigma \equiv 1$, $\alpha_n = c_n$ is nondecreasing, $\beta \equiv 0$ and $\alpha_n + \gamma_n = 1$. If $j \le i$ and $i + j \le N - 2$, then $j < N - i$, so $\alpha_j = c_j \le c_{N-i} = 1 - c_i = \gamma_i$. Theorem 7.14 applies. ∎

The hypotheses of Corollary 7.15 are inequalities in the coefficients. They contain the symmetric Krawtchouk endpoint, where the perturbation criterion of Section 5 gives no neighbourhood and where the convex counterexamples of Section 9 show that convexity alone does not suffice.

Combined with Theorem 7.8, Corollary 7.15 gives an inequality criterion for symmetric systems: an array with $b \equiv 0$ on $0, \dots, 2N$ has nonnegative linearization whenever its two normalized components satisfy the hypotheses of Corollary 7.15. For Szwarc's system (7.2) at $p_0 = 1/2$ the components are the symmetric Krawtchouk arrays on $N+1$ and N points (Corollary 7.9 with $q = r = 1$), so this case is covered by inequalities alone.

The reversal route cannot reach systems whose diagonal increases at the top. If $b_{N-1} < b_N$, the reversed array has $g'(1,1;1) = (b'_1 - b'_0)/a'_0 = (b_{N-1} - b_N)/a'_0 < 0$, so condition (b) of Theorem 7.13 fails. In particular it fails for the Krawtchouk arrays with $r < 1$ and for (7.2) with $p_0 < 1/2$, whose deep coefficients are positive only through cancellation in the formula of Theorem 7.13. Miclo's palindromic criterion [5, Theorem 31] requires $2^n P(n, n+1)$ to be nonincreasing on $[0, N/2]$, which the symmetric Krawtchouk chain violates.

8. Limits of inequality criteria

Theorems 7.10 and 7.14 control every triple except the deep ones by inequalities, and Section 9 records shape conditions that fail on deep triples. This section shows that the failure is structural near the symmetric endpoint. A criterion that acts on all sizes N by one rule cannot be a pure inequality criterion there: to first order it must impose exact equalities. Write $K_{N,r}$ for the Krawtchouk array (2.4) with $q = 1$, and use the coordinates $b_1, \dots, b_{N-1}, c_1, \dots, c_N$ of a stochastic array with $b_0 = 0$, $a_0 = 1$, $a_N = 0$, $b_N = 1 - c_N$ and $a_n = 1 - b_n - c_n$ otherwise. An affine change of x reduces every finite system to this form. A direction $v = (\delta b_1, \dots, \delta b_{N-1}, \delta c_1, \dots, \delta c_N)$ changes these coordinates; we put $\delta b_0 = \delta c_0 = 0$ and $\delta b_N = -\delta c_N$.

Lemma 8.1 *(Corner value).* *For $0 < r \le 1$, the array $K_{N,r}$ has $g(N, N; N) = (1-r)^N$.*

Proof. In the model of Lemma 5.2, $U_N = y_1 \cdots y_N$ is the only normalized basis element containing $y_{\{1,\dots,N\}}$, and $U_N^2 = \prod_i \big((1-r)y_i + r\big)$ has coefficient $(1-r)^N$ at that monomial. ∎

Thus the corner coefficient vanishes at $r = 1$, where it is a structural zero, together with the other perimeter and parity zeros of the palindromic array. The next lemma computes its first-order change exactly.

Lemma 8.2 *(Corner identity).* *Let $N \ge 2$ and $s_N = (-1)^{\lfloor N/2 \rfloor + 1} \binom{N-1}{\lfloor (N-1)/2 \rfloor}^{-1}$. Put $F = \delta b + 2\delta c$ if N is even and $F = \delta b$ if N is odd. Then*

$$\frac{d}{d\varepsilon}\, g(N, N; N)\Big|_{K_{N,1} + \varepsilon v,\ \varepsilon = 0} = s_N \sum_{n=0}^{N} (-1)^n \binom{N}{n} F(n).$$

Proof. At $K_{N,1}$ the nodes are $\lambda_j = 1 - 2j/N$, with masses $w_j = 2^{-N}\binom{N}{j}$ and $\pi_n = \binom{N}{n}$ in Lemma 5.1. Moreover $\binom{N}{n} R_n(\lambda_j)$ is the binary Krawtchouk polynomial, so that

$$\sum_{j=0}^{N} w_j R_n(\lambda_j) s^j = 2^{-N} (1+s)^{N-n} (1-s)^n. \tag{8.1}$$

The vectors $u_j = (R_n(\lambda_j))_n$ and $v_j = (w_j \pi_n R_n(\lambda_j))_n$ are right and left eigenvectors of J with $v_i^{\mathsf{T}} u_j = \mathbf{1}_{i=j}$. Since $R_N(\lambda_j) = (-1)^j$, the matrix $\Pi = R_N(J)$ reverses the indices. Let $J_\varepsilon = J + \varepsilon E$ be the perturbed recurrence matrix and R_N^ε the perturbed polynomial. The matrix $R_N^\varepsilon(J_\varepsilon)$ commutes with J_ε and has first row e_N^{T}, by (5.1). Its derivative X at $\varepsilon = 0$ therefore satisfies $[J, X] = [\Pi, E]$ and $e_0^{\mathsf{T}} X = 0$. In the eigenbasis, $X_{ij} = v_i^{\mathsf{T}} X u_j$ equals $((-1)^i - (-1)^j) E_{ij}/(\lambda_i - \lambda_j)$ for $i \neq j$, where $E_{ij} = v_i^{\mathsf{T}} E u_j$, and $\sum_i X_{ij} = 0$. By (5.1) the derivative in the lemma is $X_{NN} = \sum_{i,j} (-1)^{i+j} X_{ij} w_j$, and eliminating X_{jj} gives

$$X_{NN} \;=\; -2 \sum_{i+j \text{ odd}} X_{ij} w_j \;=\; N \sum_{i \neq j} E_{ij} w_j \frac{(-1)^i - (-1)^j}{i - j}.$$

Perturbing row n alone means $E = e_n \rho^{\mathsf{T}}$ and $E_{ij} = w_i \pi_n R_n(\lambda_i)\, \rho^{\mathsf{T}} u_j$. Write i for the imaginary unit and insert

$$\frac{(-1)^i - (-1)^j}{i - j} \;=\; -\pi \int_0^1 \sin \pi\big(\theta i + (1-\theta) j\big)\, d\theta,$$

which also vanishes for $i = j$. Then

$$X_{NN} \;=\; -\pi N \pi_n \int_0^1 \operatorname{Im}\big(A(\theta) B(\theta)\big)\, d\theta,$$
$$A = \sum_i w_i R_n(\lambda_i) e^{\mathrm{i}\pi\theta i}, \qquad B = \sum_j w_j (\rho^{\mathsf{T}} u_j) e^{\mathrm{i}\pi(1-\theta) j},$$

and both sums are given by (8.1). Put $\phi = \pi\theta/2$.

- Coordinate b_n, $1 \le n < N$, so $\rho = e_n - e_{n+1}$. Then

  $$AB \;=\; -(-1)^n\, \mathrm{i}^{N-1} \cos^N \phi\, \sin^{N-1} \phi\, e^{-\mathrm{i}\phi},$$

  and $X_{NN} = s_N (-1)^n \binom{N}{n}$. The integral reduces to $\int_0^{\pi/2} \cos^{N+1} \phi\, \sin^{N-1} \phi\, d\phi$ (N even) or $\int_0^{\pi/2} \cos^N \phi\, \sin^N \phi\, d\phi$ (N odd), and each equals $|s_N|/(2N)$.

- Coordinate c_n, $1 \le n < N$, so $\rho = e_{n-1} - e_{n+1}$. Now B acquires the factor $e^{\mathrm{i}\phi}/\cos\phi$, and the integrand carries $\sin((N-1)\pi/2)$. The contribution vanishes for odd N. For even N it is twice that of b_n, since the two beta integrals have ratio 2.

- Coordinate c_N, so $\rho = e_{N-1} - e_N$ in row N. The same computation with $n = N$ gives s_N.

Summing these contributions with the conventions $\delta b_0 = \delta c_0 = 0$ and $\delta b_N = -\delta c_N$ gives the stated alternating sum. ∎

Definition 8.3. A *uniform rule* is a pair of functions β, γ on $[0, 1]$. It defines, for each N, the direction v_N with $\delta b_n = \beta(n/N)$ for $1 \le n < N$ and $\delta c_n = \gamma(n/N)$ for $1 \le n \le N$. A set of arrays *admits* the rule at the symmetric endpoint if for all large N it contains $K_{N,1} + \varepsilon v_N$ for all small $\varepsilon > 0$. Put

$$L_{\text{even}} \;=\; \beta(0) + 2\gamma(0) + \beta(1) + \gamma(1), \qquad L_{\text{odd}} \;=\; \beta(0) - \beta(1) - \gamma(1).$$

Theorem 8.4 *(Forced equalities for uniform criteria).* *Let β, γ be polynomials. If a set of arrays with property (P) admits the rule (β, γ) at the symmetric endpoint, then $L_{\text{even}} = L_{\text{odd}} = 0$. If $L_{\text{even}} = L_{\text{odd}} = 0$, the first-order change of $g(N, N; N)$ along v_N vanishes for every N above the degrees of β and γ.*

Proof. For a polynomial p of degree less than N, $\sum_{n=0}^{N} (-1)^n \binom{N}{n} p(n/N) = 0$. Only boundary terms survive in Lemma 8.2: the derivative equals $-s_N L_{\text{even}}$ for even N and $-s_N L_{\text{odd}}$ for odd N. The sign of s_N changes from N to $N+2$. If, for instance, $L_{\text{even}} \neq 0$, then the derivative is negative for every large even N in one residue class modulo 4. For such N, $g(N, N; N) < 0$ at $K_{N,1} + \varepsilon v_N$ for all small $\varepsilon > 0$, since the coefficient vanishes at $\varepsilon = 0$. ∎

The known positive deformations satisfy both equalities: the Krawtchouk direction $\beta(x) = x$, $\gamma(x) = -x$, palindromic deformations with $\beta = 0$ and γ odd about $\frac{1}{2}$ (Corollary 7.15), and the geometric direction $\beta = 0$, $\gamma(x) = x(x-1)$ (Theorem 2.1). Consequently, for every $d \geq 0$, no set of arrays with property (P) admits all rules of an open subset of the polynomial rules of degree at most d. In this precise sense, every criterion that acts uniformly in N and contains the symmetric Krawtchouk systems carries equalities. The geometric criterion and Corollary 7.15 are of this mixed type.

The polynomial hypothesis can be replaced by analyticity on a fixed region. Let $U(x) = \int_0^1 \log|x - t|\, dt$ and $\Omega = \{x \in \mathbb{C} : U(x) \leq -1\}$, the region of convergence of equispaced interpolation. It contains $[0, 1]$, has corners at 0 and 1, and meets the line $\operatorname{Re} x = \frac{1}{2}$ at $\operatorname{Im} x = \pm 0.2628\ldots$.

Lemma 8.5 *(Nörlund–Rice bound).* *If f is analytic on an open set containing Ω, then $\sum_{n=0}^{N} (-1)^n \binom{N}{n} f(n/N) = O(\sqrt{N}\, e^{-\eta N})$ for some $\eta > 0$.*

Proof. The residues of $1/\prod_{k=0}^{N}(x - k/N)$ give

$$\sum_{n=0}^{N} (-1)^n \binom{N}{n} f(n/N) = (-1)^N \frac{N!}{N^N} \frac{1}{2\pi i} \oint_\Gamma \frac{f(x)\, dx}{\prod_{k=0}^{N}(x - k/N)}$$

for any cycle Γ in the domain of f that winds once around $[0, 1]$. Since U is continuous and tends to ∞, the compact sets $\{U \leq -1 + t\}$ shrink to Ω as $t \downarrow 0$. Choose $\eta > 0$ with $\{U \leq -1 + 3\eta\}$ inside the domain of f, and take Γ in $\{-1 + \eta < U < -1 + 3\eta\}$ winding once around $\{U \leq -1 + \eta\}$. On Γ the function $t \mapsto \log|x - t|$ has a bounded derivative on $[0, 1]$, so a Riemann-sum estimate gives $\sum_k \log|x - k/N| \geq NU(x) - C \geq N(-1 + \eta) - C$. Stirling's bound $N!/N^N \leq e\sqrt{N} e^{-N}$ completes the proof. ∎

Corollary 8.6. *Theorem 8.4 holds for β, γ analytic on an open set containing Ω.*

Proof. By Lemma 8.5, the alternating sum of $\beta + 2\gamma$ or β tends to 0. The derivative in Lemma 8.2 is therefore $s_N(-L_{\text{even}} + o(1))$ for even N and $s_N(-L_{\text{odd}} + o(1))$ for odd N. The argument of Theorem 8.4 applies. ∎

Deformations may also depend on N in other ways. For one fixed N, nothing can be excluded: the cone of first-order directions that keep property (P) at $K_{N,1}$ has nonempty interior. Exact computation confirms this for $N \le 10$: a direction with strictly positive first-order change at every structural zero exists, and the arrays $K_{N,1} + \varepsilon v$ have property (P) for $\varepsilon = 10^{-3}$ and 10^{-5}. The corner nevertheless constrains every family that is regular in N.

Proposition 8.7 *(Families depending on N).* *Let v_N be directions such that a set with property (P) contains $K_{N,1} + \varepsilon v_N$ for all large N and small $\varepsilon > 0$, and let A_N be the alternating sum in Lemma 8.2 for v_N. Then $s_N A_N \ge 0$ for all large N.*

1. *If the even-indexed (or odd-indexed) terms A_N have eventually constant sign, they vanish for all large such N.*
2. *Suppose $\delta b_n = \beta(n/N) + p_n + q_{N-n}$ and $\delta c_n = \gamma(n/N) + p'_n + q'_{N-n}$, with β, γ as in Corollary 8.6 and finitely supported boundary layers p, q, p', q' independent of N. Then $q'_0 = L_{\mathrm{even}} = L_{\mathrm{odd}}$, $p_k = q_k$ and $p'_k + q'_k = -p_k$ for $k \ge 1$.*

Proof. A negative first-order change of $g(N, N; N)$ excludes $K_{N,1} + \varepsilon v_N$ for small ε, so $s_N A_N \ge 0$. Part (1) follows because the sign of s_N alternates along each parity class. In (2), the layers contribute $\sum_{k\ge1}(-1)^k \binom{N}{k}\big[p_k + q_k + 2(p'_k + q'_k)\big] + q'_0$ for even N and $\sum_{k\ge1}(-1)^k \binom{N}{k}(p_k - q_k) + q'_0$ for odd N. These are polynomials in N, and the bulk contributes $-L + o(1)$. Part (1) forces every coefficient of these polynomials to vanish, since the binomial coefficients $\binom{N}{k}$ are linearly independent as polynomials in N. ∎

Thus a separate adjustment of the top coefficient c_N reduces the two bulk equalities to the single equality $\gamma(0) + \beta(1) + \gamma(1) = 0$. The boundary layers must be palindromic to first order. Families escaping part (1) must make the sign of A_N follow N mod 4.

Criteria that cover $r < 1$ but not $r = 1$ are thin near $r = 1$.

Proposition 8.8 *(Thinness near the symmetric endpoint).* *Fix $N \ge 2$ and a direction v along which the first-order change $\dot g$ of $g(N, N; N)$ at $K_{N,1}$ is negative. There are $r_* < 1$ and $C, c > 0$ such that $K_{N,r} + \varepsilon v$ lacks property (P) whenever $r_* < r < 1$ and $C(1-r)^N \le \varepsilon \le c$.*

Proof. The function $G(r, \varepsilon) = g(N, N; N)$ at $K_{N,r} + \varepsilon v$ is rational and smooth near $(1, 0)$. By Lemma 8.1, $G(r, 0) = (1-r)^N$, and $\partial_\varepsilon G(r, 0) \to \dot g$ as $r \to 1$. A uniform second-order Taylor bound gives $G \le (1-r)^N - \frac{3}{8}|\dot g|\varepsilon < 0$ in the stated range. ∎

Corollary 8.9 *(Optimal order of the stability radius).* *For $N \ge 2$ let $\rho_N(r)$ be the largest ρ such that every array satisfying (2.1) with $\widetilde{b}_i \ge 0$ and with left side of (5.4) at most ρ has property (P). Then $\rho_N(r)$ is of exact order $(1-r)^N$ as $r \to 1$.*

Proof. Theorem 5.3 gives $\rho_N(r) \ge \eta_N(r) = \frac{1}{2}((1-r)/(32N))^N$ for $r \ge \frac{1}{2}$. For the upper bound, choose a constant rule whose value of L_{even} (N even) or L_{odd} (N odd) has the sign of s_N. Its direction v has $\dot g < 0$ by Lemma 8.2. For $\varepsilon = C(1-r)^N$ as in Proposition 8.8,

the array $K_{N,r} + \varepsilon v$ lacks property (P), lies within $\varepsilon \max |v|$ of $K_{N,r}$, and has nonnegative diagonal for r near 1, because ε is small compared with $b_1 = (1-r)/N$. ∎

Computations away from $r = 1$. The following findings are exact computations, not proofs. They are reproduced by `rigidity_probe.py` and `smallr_probe.py`. Here $g(N, N; N)$ is computed from column N of the product table, an $O(N^2)$-operation recurrence, so sizes in the hundreds are cheap.

- For fixed $r \in (\frac{1}{2}, 1)$ the first-order change of $g(N, N; N)$ along simple rules is of order 2^{-N} with signs of period 4, while the coefficient itself is $(1-r)^N$. Fixed-size deformations accordingly fail at $r = 4/5$ for every N from 6 to 14, and at $r = 19/20$ for every N from 4 to 14.

- Below $r = \frac{1}{2}$, counterexamples to shape conditions appear only at large N, roughly $N \approx 5/r^2$. For constant-ratio arrays with convex profile, one-kink counterexamples (m unit increments, then $1 + \delta$) have $g(N, N; N) < 0$ at

r	2/5	1/3	3/10	1/4	2/7	1/5	1/10
N	20	40	40	60	80	100	500

  Concave profiles fail for $N \leq 18$ at every tested r.

- Convex profiles with log-concave increments (step ratios nonincreasing and at least 1) contain Krawtchouk, every geometric profile, and smooth convex profiles, and they exclude the one-kink counterexamples. Yet k steps of ratio $1 + 1/(2N)$ followed by flat increments give $g(N, N; N) < 0$ at $(r, N, k) = (\frac{1}{2}, 80, 40)$, $(\frac{2}{5}, 32, 22)$ and $(\frac{1}{3}, 90, 62)$ in exact arithmetic. In 80- and 150-digit arithmetic the same happens at $(\frac{1}{4}, 250, 175)$ and $(\frac{1}{5}, 500, 400)$.

Every inequality shape class tested for constant-ratio arrays thus fails at every tested r between 1/10 and $\frac{1}{2}$. Only smooth deformations, which finitely many local inequalities cannot enforce, survived the corner up to $N = 200$.

9. Open problems

Inequalities beyond geometric increments. The geometric criterion imposes exact equalities, whereas the perturbation criterion provides small neighborhoods. Find direct inequalities on successive recurrence coefficients that cover larger nonclassical regions while retaining the full Krawtchouk range. The terminating row and products of degree sum greater than N must remain part of the conclusion.

Sharper stability radii. For fixed N and $0 < r < 1$, determine or estimate the largest coefficient radius for which every admissible stochastic perturbation has property (P). Corollary 8.9 shows that the order $(1-r)^N$ as $r \to 1$ is optimal; the dependence on N, and on r away from 1, remains open. The bound in Theorem 5.3 comes from a single-term lower

margin and a worst-case recurrence amplification. Both estimates discard substantial information. A useful improvement would retain a transparent coefficient test and describe its dependence on both N and the bias parameter.

The symmetric endpoint. At $r = 1$, the reference margin in Lemma 5.2 vanishes because parity forces many coefficients to be zero. Symmetric perturbations preserve the parity zeros, and Theorem 7.6 exploits this for Szwarc's quadratic system when $p_0 < 1/2$. At $p_0 = 1/2$, and for the symmetric Krawtchouk array, further coefficients on the parity support vanish. Determine perturbation directions and structural constraints that preserve positivity there; continuity alone does not control coefficients emerging from those zeros. For each fixed $N \le 10$ the admissible first-order directions form a cone with nonempty interior, but Theorem 8.4 and Proposition 8.7 show that no rule acting uniformly in N reaches that interior through an open set. A description of the cone for all N is open.

Monotonicity-type criteria for finite systems. Szwarc's Theorems 3.2 and 3.3 in [6] are open conditions of monotonicity type for infinite systems. For finite systems, property (P) at the boundary point is the hypergroup property of the corresponding birth–death chain, and Miclo [5, Theorem 31 and Proposition 6] adapts the wave-equation argument of Bakry and Huet to give inequality conditions for chains that are symmetric under $n \mapsto N - n$ and sufficiently convex. Those conditions exclude the Krawtchouk recurrence and the system (7.1). By Theorem 7.8, any criterion of this kind for nonsymmetric finite systems, valid including the terminal indices, immediately gives one for symmetric finite systems. Theorem 7.10 supplies such hypotheses for all triples except those whose pairwise sums all exceed N; the remaining task is to control these deep triples by inequalities that contain the geometric criterion. Convexity of the profile does not suffice even with a constant ratio and r bounded away from 1: for d with increments 1 at the first seven steps and $6/5$ at the remaining seven ($N = 14$), exact arithmetic gives $g(14, 14; 14) < 0$ at $r = 1/2$, and the analogous profile with $N = 20$, twelve unit increments and $21/20$ afterwards gives $g(20, 20; 20) < 0$ at $r = 2/5$. Log-convex increments fail as well: fourteen unit increments followed by $(21/20)^t$, $t = 1, \dots, 4$, give $g(18, 18; 18) < 0$ at $r = 1/2$. The admissible bias for such profiles therefore shrinks with N, and the terminal product is where positivity fails. Section 8 explains part of this: near $r = 1$ every criterion acting uniformly in N must impose equalities, and below $r = \frac{1}{2}$ the convex, concave and log-concave convex shape classes all have exact counterexamples once N is of order $5/r^2$. Two questions remain. First, prove the exponential thinness observed for fixed $r \in (\frac{1}{2}, 1)$. Second, decide whether any inequality criterion, necessarily one that enforces smoothness of the profile, covers a range $0 < r \le r_0$ for all N. Szwarc-type certificates do not resolve the deep triples either. For each Krawtchouk array tested ($N \le 8$, $r \in \{1, 1/2, 1/5\}$) every deep coefficient is a nonnegative combination of non-deep coefficients through the relations $Hu = 0$ on a backward cone, but the weights must depend on the coefficients: no single weight serves $r = 1/5$ and $r = 1/2$, so no family of linear inequalities obtained this way contains the Krawtchouk range. Checkerboard-supported weights fail for every tested $r < 1$, and the canonical weight solving $H^* v = 0$ on the deep region has negative boundary flux. On random perturbed

arrays the existence of such certificates coincided with property (P).

Other finite families. Find analogous coefficient regions around other finite orthogonal systems and compare their geometry with the Krawtchouk neighborhoods. An algebra with a positive basis may supply the reference margin, but a recurrence criterion must express the resulting admissible deformations without requiring the unknown product coefficients as input.

AI-use disclosure

OpenAI Codex was used to develop the proof arguments, search and check source passages, construct exact-arithmetic diagnostics, draft and revise this manuscript, and prepare the Lean translation. Separate AI-assisted reviews checked the algebraic proof, boundary cases, normalizations, and quantitative estimates; these reviews are not human peer review. Anthropic Claude was used to analyse Szwarc's Problem 2 against the survey text, to explore discrete hyperbolic certificates numerically, and to develop and draft Sections 7 and 8 together with their exact diagnostics; these sections have not been independently reviewed. The author set the research objective and retains responsibility for publication decisions and the final mathematical claims. No independent human verification is asserted here. Statements about machine verification refer only to the specific compiled Lean declarations and their documented dependencies, not to the presence of a Lean project or to numerical agreement.

Code and formalization

The companion source tree contains `probe.py` and `verify.py`. The command

```
python3 -u verify.py --max-n 7
```

compares recurrence-matrix multiplication with direct multiplication modulo the terminal polynomial on exact rational inputs, checks the perturbation lower bounds, and replays two rejected coefficient-profile tests. It also checks Theorem 7.1, the margin of Lemma 7.4 and the negative coefficient for $p_0 > 1/2$ on exact Szwarc arrays, the identities of Lemma 7.3 in the graded model, and the lower bound of Theorem 7.6 on rational symmetric perturbations. These computations are diagnostics and do not replace the proofs at arbitrary size. For Section 8, `rigidity_probe.py` checks Lemma 8.2 exactly for $N \leq 20$, the predicted failures of Theorem 8.4, the boundary layers of Proposition 8.7, the region of Lemma 8.5 and the fixed-r computations, and `smallr_probe.py` replays the small-r counterexamples.

The Lean development formalizes the two main criteria as follows:

Paper result	Lean declaration
Theorem 2.1: geometric criterion	`Szkraw.geometric_criterion`
Theorem 5.3: perturbation	`Szkraw.perturbation_criterion`

The first includes a positive finite orthogonality measure, distinct support points, the terminal relation, and all finite product identities. The second includes the explicit radius, positive triangle margin, and exact zeros outside the triangle. Both have compiled proofs without added axioms or admitted goals. The results of Section 7 have not been formalized.

The companion code is available at `https://github.com/skypher/szkraw`; the fixed revision cited in [8] identifies the reviewed proof and audit code. Run `make lean` to build the development and `make axioms` to build and audit the principal statements. The latter invokes `lean/CheckAxioms.lean`, which rejects dependencies outside `propext`, `Classical.choice`, and `Quot.sound` and tests rejection of unexpected axioms. The toolchain and dependencies are pinned in `lean/lean-toolchain` and `lean/lake-manifest.json`. The declaration-by-declaration correspondence, auxiliary formalization coverage, and verification commands are recorded in `RESEARCH.md` at that revision. Historical attribution and the open problems are prose claims, not machine-verified statements.

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